

Cat & Company

24 pp

Issue 1

That's How I Escaped My Certain Fate

David White

Page 1

Panel 1 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Space! Low orbital space just above the planet LV-4209 (“Bong”). A **Corporate frigate** seems to hang in vacuum while it moves terrifyingly fast in orbital free fall. Red lights blink on the outside of the spherical “head” of the ship. If you feel like drawing portholes, keep in mind that “up” for the crew will point to the front of the sphere. The portholes will be a source of red light.

Box (*PA announcement, upper left of panel*)

SELF DESTRUCT INITIATED. PROCEED TO ESCAPE CAPSULES IMMEDIATELY. REPEAT–

Panel 1a (*Small square inset into Panel 1, lower left*):

A small image of uniformed Fe Arran crew running down a hallway, inset into Panel 1.

Panel 1b (*Small square inset into Panel 1, lower right*):

A small image of crewmen sitting on benches inside a cylindrical escape pod.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis lies on her belly in a narrow maintenance duct illuminated with red light. She is typing on an incongruously “retro” keyboard attached to an access port on the wall, and looks into a glowing green display.

Box (*PA announcement, upper left of panel*)

SELF DESTRUCT INITIATED. PROCEED TO ESCAPE CAPSULES IMMEDIATELY. REPEAT–

SF/X (*Mechanical keyboard noises*)

clackety-clackety-clack

Box (*green text, like an old computer terminal*)

WARNING: Safety interlocks disabled!

WARNING: IFF systems disabled!

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*)

Escape capsules are jettisoned from the spherical crew compartment.

Box (*green text, like an old computer terminal*)

WARNING: Activating Point Defense Grid may injure or kill crew performing EVAs. Are you sure (Y/N)?

Panel 4 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*)

The point defense grid of the **Corporate frigate** opens fire on the escape pods, destroying them.

SF/X (*Mechanical keyboard noises, upper left*)

clack-CLACK

Box (*green text, like an old computer terminal, immediately next to the sound effect of an old keyboard*)

Y

Page 2

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis pushes open an access panel beneath the now abandoned bridge of the **Corporate frigate**. The bridge is illuminated with red light, and various warning lights blink frantically.

Box (*PA announcement, upper left of panel*)

SELF DESTRUCT INITIATED. PROCEED TO ESCAPE CAPSULES IMMEDIATELY. REPEAT–

Box (*Jinx Bubastis, narration, bottom of panel*)

My name is Jinx Bubastis. Back in the day, I was a super-powered space pirate “heel” for the Corporation’s *Fun Division*

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis flips a switch on one of the rear panels of the bridge, which restores normal lighting and calms down the flashing warning lights. She is wearing a heavy environmental protection suit, vaguely resembling a space suit, but much lighter. She carries a matching helmet under her other arm.

Jinx Bubastis

Oh, *shut up!*

Box (*Jinx Bubastis, narration, bottom of panel*)

I’m not sure what I am now. This one’s off the books, a mission of mercy to save an old love.

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis is now at the communications station. (*Note: is this reminding you of the bridge layout in “Star Trek”? This is intentional. It shouldn’t be an exact copy, though.*) She scowls at a screen. A light labeled “Message pending” blinks on the panel, but she concentrates on what looks like a map on the screen.

Box (*Narration, top right of panel*)

As above...

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The interior of a bunker on the surface of the planet. A uniformed Fe Arran **Corporate crewman (1)** scowls at the screen of his communications station. This would invite visual symmetry with Panel 3.

Box (*Jinx Bubastis, narration, bottom left of panel, beneath the narration box from Panel 3*)

...so below.

The surface of LV-4209, a/k/a “Bong”. It’s less fun than it sounds.

Corporate crewman (1)

No response from the ship, sir!

Panel 5 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Corporate crewman (1) looks over his shoulder at **Corporate crewman (2)**, a male Fe Arran in a maintenance jumpsuit caught in mid-shrug, and **Corporate crew chief**, a frazzled-looking uniformed female Fe Arran holding a bottle of antacid tablets.

Corporate crew chief (1)

Alert the surface patrols.

Corporate crewman (1)

Yes, sir!

Corporate crew chief

How’s the prisoner doing?

Corporate crewman (2)

No news is good news.

Page 3

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A fire team of four Fe Arrans in powered armor on the surface of LV-4209. The ground is covered with bubbling water, and as the bubbles burst, they release tendrils of organic residue that stain the fire team's armor. Sight is limited in range and obscured by smoky fog. The Lancer (team leader) is using a device resembling a pair of binoculars to try to make out distant features or potential targets. The other three go to a kneeling posture with their bulky rifles at their shoulders.

Lancer (*Electronically distorted*)

Possible contact, sending coordinates.

Corporate crew chief (1) (*over the Lancer's radio, electronically distorted*)

Roger, engage at your discretion.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The panel should look like a view through the Lancer's optic, with what may be a figure marked with a selection bounding box.

Lancer

Ready?

Soldier (1)

Yes, sir!

Lancer:

Location sent, light 'em up!

Panel 3 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis, dressed in a full-body environmental suit with her helmet on, quietly walks up behind and to the left of the **Lancer**, who is looking through his optic to determine if the fire team's fire is having any effect. The fire team is completely focused down range; after no immediate effect from their first shots, they are suppressing the area around where the **Lancer** identified a potential target.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis taps the **Lancer** on the shoulder. The **Lancer** is trying to find the target he sighted earlier.

Jinx Bubastis (*Electronically distorted*)

A little to your left.

Panel 5 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Back in the bunker, **Corporate crewman (1)** relays some unfortunate news from his communication station screen.

Corporate crewman (1)

Sir? Contact lost with surface patrol.

Corporate chief (*off-panel*)

Oh, shit.

Page 4

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis, still in her environmental suit, approaches the outer airlock door of the bunker. She makes a peculiar gesture and pronounces a magical word of power – most readers should be able to guess that she has just cast a spell.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The outer door slides open, and **Jinx Bubastis** enters the airlock.

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Inside the bunker control room. **Corporate crewman (1)** has turned away from the panel to face **Corporate crewman (2)** and **Corporate chief**, who in turn are standing off to the side and behind him. **Corporate chief** is holding a bottle of antacid tablets.

Corporate crewman (1)

My contract says I get notice if Fun Division sends in some freak.

Corporate chief

Come on, who do you think would come here?

Corporate crewman (2)

You know who we have in back. Take a wild guess.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Corporate chief looks crestfallen, as she realizes the implications of what she's saying.

Corporate chief (upper left)

Listen, I got a career, I got a life. *Fun Division* wouldn't just kill us off for cheap drama...

Corporate chief (lower right)

Oh, *fuck* me.

Panel 5 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat lies slack-jawed on an advanced hospital bed. His eyes are open as well, but he doesn't look conscious. In the background, **Jinx Bubastis** removes her helmet.

Box (Narration, bottom of panel)

Let's see what those bastards did to you.

Page 5

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis touches **Peter Cat**'s temples as she whispers into his ear.

Jinx Bubastis (*Upper left*)

You gave me a memory a long time ago, let me try to give it back.

Jinx Bubastis (*Lower right, whisper, a phrase with magical power*)

"Let me patch your state."

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis recoils as **Peter Cat** suddenly awakens. There is a sound of a muffled explosion inside his skull.

SF/X

POIT!

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Inside the darkened bunker control room, the **Corporate chief** looks at a display bearing very bad news. **Corporate crewman (2)** tries to cheer her up.

Corporate chief

He's awake.

Corporate crewman (2)

Well, I hear vaporization doesn't hurt at all. It's a good way to go.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The door to the darkened room opens, and **Peter Cat** and **Jinx Bubastis** stand in the doorway. **Peter Cat** has made a complete recovery, and is explaining something to **Jinx Bubastis**.

Peter Cat

—so after force-growth, a clone brain is filled with random neural connections. The drug they gave me clears those out for conditioning.

Jinx Bubastis

Which means your powers interpreted it as a medicine, and not a poison.

Peter Cat

Exactly! Clever, don't you think?

Panel 5 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The **Corporate chief**, **Corporate crewman (1)**, and **Corporate crewman (2)** cower in a corner. **Jinx Bubastis** gently pokes **Peter Cat** in the ribs with her elbow.

Jinx Bubastis

You know, it's healthy and normal to be angry at the people who did this to you.

Peter Cat

Maybe, but I think we've already attracted too much attention —

Panel 6 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Corporate chief, **Corporate crewman (1)**, and **Corporate crewman (2)** stand in a triangle in front of the communications console, side-eyeing each other.

Box (*Peter Cat, continued, upper left*)

"—and it's funnier and crueler if we let them decide which one gets to tell Head Office about this screw-up."

Box (*Peter Cat, continued, lower right*)

“Let’s, uh, blow this joint.”

Page 6

Panel 1 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis' Mark IX corvette hangs in space behind an asteroid loosely orbiting LV-4209. The panoramic window is set to “transparent”, and the speech balloons come from there (12 o'clock to 2 o'clock in the main hull). The booms are set for cruising through space, about 120° relative to each other, surrounding the crew hull.

Box (Jinx Bubastis, narration, upper left)

It wasn't long before we were back on *my* ship.

Peter Cat (from inside the ship)

A Mark IX? Nice, they fix up well. I like the window!

Jinx Bubastis (from inside the ship)

Got it cheap off some drug smugglers.

Had to strip out the dance floor, hot tubs, and orgy pits.

I think they wanted to make it their *party van*.

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Peter Cat stands in front of the window in the foreground, looking at the stars. (Note: keep in mind which direction “up” is, the view won't contain any objects from Panel 1.) **Jinx Bubastis** stands next to him. It bears repeating that this is the only open, airy space in the ship; the rest of it is tight and utilitarian.

Peter Cat

I'm guessing you didn't rescue me just for kicks.

Jinx Bubastis

Well, not *just* for kicks, I missed you.

And yeah, things got messy.

Peter Cat

I'm listening.

Panel 3 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Now **Jinx Bubastis** is in the foreground. She speaks to the ship's computer. **Peter Cat** frowns.

Jinx Bubastis

Hey, *Shithead*! Put up “Analysis - 24 - rev 1” up on the *porn hub*!

Peter Cat

Don't call the ship computer that, it'll get mad and try to space us.

Panel 4 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis and **Peter Cat** turn to face a large holographic projection in the middle of the room. It looks like a three-dimensional analog of a false-color image of a cosmological radio source. **Jinx Bubastis** points to the center of the roughly spherical blob.

Jinx Bubastis

I've been busy, I haven't had time to fiddle with the UI theme.

This is what the Corporation's *creatives* call *Source*.

It's an expanding shell of modulated long wave photons coming from this yellow dwarf here in the center.

Media drones spend lifetimes *radio mining* ideas for new products and services for *the Corporation* from it.

Peter Cat

I've heard of *Source*. Head Office makes a big deal of how secret it is, but it's about 160 Cosmological Units* across.

Takes up over two fifths of a radian of sky, it's huge.

Box (writer's note, lower right)

* A “Cosmological Unit” or “CU” is the distance a photon travels in a peculiarly arbitrary interval of time. As you can probably guess by now, this distance is almost exactly what humans call a “light-year”.

Page 7

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A close-up on **Jinx Bubastis**, scratching her chin as she starts speaking. She is eager to explain her findings.

Jinx Bubastis

The Corporation isn't kidding about keeping it secret.
Get this—

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat stands, looking down, arms crossed, as **Jinx Bubastis** continues.

Jinx Bubastis (off-panel)

—if a navigator running the standard *Corporate software distro* sees the location coordinates correspond too closely to the middle of *Source*, it'll trigger an automated self-destruct sequence.
Turned it into a pretty handy exploit.

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat looks up and turns a little towards **Jinx Bubastis** with a slightly concerned look on his face.

Peter Cat

So, we're going there, but *how*?

Jinx Bubastis

I got my hands on a salvaged *Reyll navigator*, set it up with help from an ex-POW.

Peter Cat

Enemy tech? That'll work.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A close up of **Peter Cat**, who is starting to smile a little.

Peter Cat

I'm liking this. Go nice and far from Corporate space to look at something they pretend doesn't exist, where no one can follow us.

Panel 5 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis make a sweeping gesture with her arms to zoom in on the diagram of *Source*. **Peter Cat** watches with interest after the view centers on the yellow dwarf star.

Jinx Bubastis

Ok, now listen to this...

Page 8

Panel 1 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

Peter Cat bends over and squints to view a tiny blue dot highlighted with a yellow wireframe cube. A flat quad (a textured, 2D rectangular surface) linked to the cube shows the display of a waveform. **Jinx Bubastis** stands behind him and grins.

Peter Cat

What's *that* supposed to be?

Jinx Bubastis

An FTL carrier wave.

Peter Cat

Huh. *Shithead*, would you please use this FTL signal to modulate a 400 cycle audio sine wave?

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Peter Cat stands up and listens attentively.

SF/X

DOOT DOOT DOOT dit dit dit DOOT DOOT DOOT

Panel 3 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Peter Cat turns to **Jinx Bubastis**. The distress call continues playing in the background.

SF/X

DOOT DOOT DOOT dit dit dit DOOT DOOT DOOT

Peter Cat

That's an archaic distress call, but they're modulating it directly on the carrier. Weird!

Panel 4 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

Peter Cat smiles warmly at **Jinx Bubastis**.

Jinx Bubastis

I have a course laid in already.

Peter Cat

This is trouble, but it's *interesting* trouble.
Let's go!

Title

That's How I Escaped My Certain Fate

Page 9

Panel 1 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

The arc of Earth, North America beneath clouds. The terminator – the line between night and dawn – goes right through Buffalo, New York.

Box (upper left)

It's morning in America...

Box (lower right)

...at least in Buffalo.

Panel 2 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

The Magister slurps from a cup of coffee. He is sitting at a bar. Behind the bar, the **Bartender** is cleaning a glass with a rag. Up to the right, a TV on an articulated arm shows a newscast, where an **Anchorwoman** speaks.

Bartender

Whut?

The Magister

Ahh, nothing.

Anchorwoman (from TV)

Meanwhile, the siege in *Phoenicia, New York* continues. Federal authorities claim that *illegal experiments* with *radioactive material* have endangered the *whole county*. The National Guard has been mobilized to surround the *compound* on the *outskirts of town*—

Mystical voice (lower left, near the Magister, a word of power whispered into his ear from deep in the World of Ash)

THEY ARE COMING.

THEY WILL BE HERE SOON.

Panel 3 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

The Magister dials a number on a burner phone.

The Magister

Could you mute the TV?

Bartender (off-panel)

Sure.

Panel 4 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

The Magister listens to his phone as it rings the remote number.

SF/X (Telephone)

BOOOOP

BOOOOP

Panel 5 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

A **TA-955 field telephone** rings on a desk in a military tent.

TA-955 field telephone

DRRRRRRT

DRRRRRRT

Box (narration, lower right)

Engagement Area: just outside Phoenicia, New York

Page 10

Panel 1 (*1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A **Colonel** picks up the field telephone handset.

Colonel

Alpha-Zero-Six, who is speaking?

Panel 2 (*1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The Magister grins like an idiot and sits up at the bar when the **Colonel** picks up his phone.

The Magister

Oh, hi there!

Panel 3 (*1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The **Colonel** has his eyes glaze over as he holds the handset to his ear.

The Magister (*a voice of power, a telepathic transmission directly into the brain of the Colonel*)

Do not worry about the unsecured line. An eavesdropper will hear nothing.

Panel 4 (*2/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Inside his mind, the **Colonel** stands before a high podium, holding the handset to his ear. The figure sitting at the podium (**the Magister**) is only visible in silhouette; blinding light comes from a glowing “eye in the pyramid” symbol in the background.

The Magister (*a voice of power, a telepathic transmission directly into the brain of the Colonel*)

You will receive visitors soon.
They will come from the sky.
Pull your men back.
DO NOT ENGAGE.

Panel 5 (*1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The **Colonel** snaps out of his altered state of consciousness and speaks into the handset.

Colonel

Yes, sir, I will!

Panel 6 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The Magister presses the button to hang up on his cheap mobile phone. The **Bartender** pauses drying the glass he was holding and side-eyes **The Magister**.

Bartender

What was that?

Panel 7 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The Magister gives his best “Alfred E. Neumann” shit-eating grin.

The Magister

Didn't hear a thing!

Page 11

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A **Sergeant** commands several **Soldiers** to withdraw from the fortifications surrounding **Camillo Skragg's house**. In the sky behind and above him, something like a shooting star twinkles in the background; it is a **Mark IX corvette** leaving behind a trail of plasma as it decelerates and enters Earth's atmosphere. From this distance, only the meteor-like plasma trail is visible.

Sergeant (*shouting*)

MOVE IT! MOVE IT!

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The cockpit of the **Mark IX corvette**. This is very much *not* the open space they were in on Pages 6 to 8. The room is a rounded cylinder. **Jinx Bubastis** sits at the front helm console, operating a control yoke that at least somewhat resembles flight controls from a real-world aircraft. Levers and displays on articulated arms are mounted on a ceiling console. Behind her are four stations facing consoles on the side of the capsule. **Peter Cat** sits directly behind her, bent over a sensor display. He has switched this over to a large glowing green screen and a retractable mechanical keyboard on a hinged mount, and is bent over the console to avoid bumping his head.

Jinx Bubastis

Shields down.

Entering atmospheric flight.

Peter Cat

I found the signal, sending it to helm.

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Behind a ground-floor window of **Camillo Skragg's house**, **Penny Skragg** pulls a curtain to the side and peers outside. She's trying to keep her head down, but see what's going on outside.

Penny Skragg

Uncle?

The soldiers are falling back.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The booms of the **Mark IX corvette** are positioned fully to the rear, over the main hull; the main drive is providing thrust upwards. The ship looks like a crossbreed between a boat and a helicopter, and using the main drive at very low output to provide upwards thrust, like a helicopter's rotors. The smaller drives on the end of the booms are slightly rotated in an upside-down 'V' formation. The flight regime of the ship is very much like a helicopter, and it's flying much slower than UFOs from modern lore. It proceeds at low altitude over the Catskill mountains.

Jinx Bubastis (*from inside the crew hull*)

Almost there.

Peter Cat (*from inside the crew hull*)

I'll give us some cover.

Panel 5 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Inside a darkened ground-floor room of **Camillo Skragg's house**. **Camillo Skragg** sits on the floor, and watches **Penny Skragg** duck down from peeking through the window.

Camillo Skragg

Keep your head down, Penny.

Penny Skragg

Uncle?

Something's happening outside.

Panel 6 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat hovers in the air, energy visibly crackling around his hands, and keeps watch as **Jinx Bubastis** sets down the **Mark IX corvette** on the highway running in front of **Camillo Skragg's house**.

Page 12

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

From behind the front door of **Camillo Skragg's house**, **Jinx Bubastis** pronounces a *word of power*, identical to the one she used in Page 4, Panel 1. The mundane locks on the door open, with the deadbolt making a prominent noise.

SF/X (*deadbolt on the upper left of the door*)

Clunk!

SF/X (*lock in the doorknob*)

Click-clack!

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis opens the door and leans inside. She is visible in silhouette; the front room is dark, and it's brighter outside.

Jinx Bubastis

Hey!

Did you guys send a *distress call*?

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg and **Penny Skragg** are illuminated by the light from the open front door. They look at each other, unsure how to interpret what is happening.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg and **Penny Skragg** look at **Jinx Bubastis** (off-panel) – it should look like they are looking at the reader. Their expressions are still puzzled.

Camillo Skragg

Y-yes?

That was, uh, me.

Panel 5 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg and **Penny Skragg** run through the front yard towards the **Mark IX corvette** sitting on the highway. **Jinx Bubastis** calls after them.

Jinx Bubastis

Airlock's in the back!

Watch your heads!

Page 13

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Inside the ship, **Jinx Bubastis** closes the airlock behind her. **Camillo Skragg** and **Penny Skragg** sit on the floor of the compartment with the large window, which is currently set to opaque. They huddle next to each other, obviously scared.

Jinx Bubastis

All right, just sit down.

Hold still so the inertial compensators can do their thing.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg looks at **Penny Skragg**. **Penny Skragg** is looking off into the distance with a thousand yard stare. They sit on the floor and lean against the wall.

Camillo Skragg

Did you forget my meds this morning?

Penny Skragg

No.

Camillo Skragg

You forgot my meds and I'm having a psychotic break.

Penny Skragg

Then what about me?

Camillo Skragg

See, *I'm* having a delusion that *you're* hallucinating.

That makes sense, right?

Panel 3 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat passes harmlessly through the outer hull and touches down gracefully. He does this by manipulating the matter of his own body, and there's a kind of "body of smoke" effect as he puts himself back together. **Camillo Skragg** and **Penny Skragg** observe this with astonishment.

Peter Cat

Hey! Jinx!

I think they're launching something, we'd better get out of here!

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Seen from the point of view of **Camillo Skragg** and **Penny Skragg**, **Peter Cat** turns towards the cowering humans, smiles, and waves. His toothy smile reveals a large mouth filled with sharp teeth, so his friendly gesture doesn't have the intended effect.

Peter Cat

Hi there!

We'll be with you in a bit.

Panel 5 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg and **Penny Skragg** try to hide behind each other on the floor as **Peter Cat** rushes off to the cockpit in the crew hull.

Penny Skragg

Nah, I'm *definitely* hallucinating.

Camillo Skragg

It's not just me?

Page 14

Panel 1 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Inside the bridge, **Jinx Bubastis** ramps up the throttle on the main drive as **Peter Cat** sits down at one of the rear seats.

Jinx Bubastis

So, were *you* expecting crystal spires and togas?

Peter Cat

Nope. Didn't know what to expect.

Jinx Bubastis

Guess *I* was.

What the *fuck* was that?

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Close up on **Peter Cat**. He scratches his chin thoughtfully as he reminisces.

Peter Cat

Wait a bit, I think I know...

...back when I was with *Honor Guard* we had a movie night.

Panel 3 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

A much younger and very nerdy **Peter Cat** sits on the edge of his seat in a darkened movie theater. He is wearing his **Arsenal** costume, holding a paper box of *tissue puffs*, a popcorn like snack, and munching on a few as he stares wide-eyed at the screen.

Box (narration, Peter Cat)

They were showing that old disaster movie with the *mysterious signal* from a gas giant and *the rogue AI* that kills the crew.

Panel 4 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Young **Peter Cat** is seen from behind, as an astronaut in a bulky EVA vacuum suit falls into a surreal tunnel – their adaptation of the scene from “2001: A Space Odyssey” where Dave Bowman’s psychedelic journey is beginning.

Box (narration, Peter Cat)

They find the source of the signal, and it pulls the only survivor into this surreal vision.

I guess *that* was what I was expecting.

Panel 5 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Back in the cockpit, **Jinx Bubastis** checks an altitude display. **Peter Cat** jabs a button and speaks into a microphone to make an announcement for the cargo bay.

Jinx Bubastis

I think we're high enough.

Starting extraction.

Peter Cat

Please lie down and try to remain calm.

Panel 6 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

A view of the skies above the Catskills. A thunderclap rolls across the mountains. Even in the bright morning light, a streak of plasma is visible, trailing off as the **Mark IX corvette** takes off into space.

SF/X

THAKOOOOOMMMMMM

Page 15

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Sitting at his console, **Peter Cat** switches his screen to view the cargo bay where **Camillo Skragg** and **Penny Skragg** are.

Peter Cat
Hmm.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat leans forward, putting his elbows on the console and interlacing his fingers beneath his chin. He looks intently into the screen.

Peter Cat
Hey, Jinx...

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat turns to **Jinx Bubastis**, who is off panel. On the screen, an image of **Camillo Skragg** and **Penny Skragg** cowering together in the cargo bay is somewhat recognizable.

Peter Cat
...I was never good at emoting, but I think I recognize *abject terror* when I see it.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat leans on the console as he turns to talk to **Jinx Bubastis**.

Peter Cat
This planet has a big satellite, right?
Do you think you can set down there?

Panel 5 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The **Mark IX corvette** sets down on the surface of the Moon.

Box *(Peter Cat, continued)
Land so they can see their home world through the window.
I think they need some help.

Page 16

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat walks down a narrow hallway, followed closely by **Jinx Bubastis**. **Peter Cat** looks a little lost in thought, but is interrupted by a gently smiling **Jinx Bubastis**.

Jinx Bubastis

Hey, Peter...

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat looks over his shoulder, as **Jinx Bubastis** continues.

Jinx Bubastis

...you're getting better at being *nice*.

Peter Cat

Thanks.

Panel 3 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat and **Jinx Bubastis** walk through the sliding door to the cargo bay. **Penny Skragg** seems to have recovered a little, and notices the door opening. **Camillo Skragg** is still sitting on the floor, holding his head. **Penny Skragg** is frowning, and has a look of aggressive skepticism on her face.

Peter Cat

Hello, again.

I'm sure you have a *lot* of questions—

Penny Skragg

You're *damn* right I do!

Panel 4 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Front and center is a banal safety sign next to the door frame, an upward pointing arrow marked "THIS WAY UP". **Penny Skragg** points at it like she is making an accusation. **Peter Cat** looks down at it; there is an awkward moment.

Penny Skragg

Why the *HELL* is that *SIGN* in *ENGLISH*!?

Peter Cat

Ah.

Page 17

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat begins explaining.

Peter Cat

Most ships have *simulated gravity*, so it's a *safety convention* to indicate which way is *up* when you go through a door–

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis looks **Penny Skragg** straight in the eyes and does her best “I am dead serious” face.

Jinx Bubastis

That's not what she's asking about.

You...

...are *ancient aliens* who have had a profound influence on our *culture*.

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Penny Skragg stares at **Jinx Bubastis** with obvious disbelief. **Camillo Skragg**, still sitting on the floor, looks up a little.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Largely the same composition as Panel 3 – **Penny Skragg** emphatically expresses her disbelief, and **Camillo Skragg** mumbles.

Penny Skragg

We're not *ANCIENT ALIENS*!

We're two *assholes* from the *Catskills*!

Camillo Skragg (*mumbling*)

Hey, both things can be true at once.

Panel 5 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*)

Close up on **Camillo Skragg**, who seems to be coming to terms with the situation.

Camillo Skragg

So, you're *really* speaking English?

This isn't some *space magic bullshit*?

Page 6 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*)

Jinx Bubastis acknowledges **Camillo Skragg's** question.

Exactly.

Also, *space magic* is *real* and *can* hurt you.

Page 18

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg stands up, and chuckles a little.

Camillo Skragg

Yeah, no *shit*.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Penny Skragg is visibly relieved to see **Camillo Skragg** on his feet and moving around.

Camillo Skragg

In case you're wondering, I built that transmitter.
Right now, I'm having a major case of *déjà vu*.

Panel 3 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg walks up to **Peter Cat**.

Camillo Skragg

Any chance you could show us around?

Peter Cat

Of course!

Fair warning, though – this is the only open space on the ship.

Jinx Bubastis

Yeah, the rest of it is pretty close quarters.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat, **Jinx Bubastis**, **Camillo Skragg**, and **Penny Skragg** walk in single file down the narrow hallway leading from the cargo bay. They are in two groups, and **Peter Cat** and **Camillo Skragg** are more fully visible.

Peter Cat

So, tell me about your transmitter.

Camillo Skragg

The oscillator is pretty boring, the fun part's the power amplifier.
It's a big-ass traveling wave vacuum tube.

Panel 5 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A close-up on **Camillo Skragg** as he talks.

Camillo Skragg

See, *thorium metal* has a *ton* of orbitals, right?

It took something like *two hundred tries*, but I eventually got a helix that did the right kind of *quantum entanglement* to resonate *non-locally*.

Page 19

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Penny Skragg talks, and rolls her eyes a little.

Penny Skragg

Yeah, and when we started going through *kilos of radioactive metal* the authorities got *concerned*.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg talks, and looks up a little as he remembers.

Camillo Skragg

So they send these *D.o.E. chuds* around to ask questions, and I'm thinking...
...I don't know what I *can* and *can't* tell them.

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg looks down as he recounts a bad memory.

Camillo Skragg

See, I picked up how to do this stuff in a *secret government lab*.
When their *black budget* got *cut off*, they shut it down and tried to *erase my memories* with *drugs*.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg continues. **Penny Skragg** looks over to make sure he's OK.

Camillo Skragg

Never believe anyone who says there are *memory-erasing drugs*.
All you end up with are *amnesiacs*.
Spent a while in a *mental hospital* after that.

Panel 5 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A side view of the hallway in the crew hull leading past the door to the bridge. **Peter Cat** and **Jinx Bubastis** stand on one side of the door, and **Camillo Skragg** and **Penny Skragg** stand on the other. **Peter Cat** looks **Camillo Skragg** in the eye, and **Camillo Skragg** holds his head high. **Penny Skragg** touches him on the shoulder.

Peter Cat

That's awful.
I'm so sorry.

Camillo Skragg

Thing is, *life goes on*.

Page 20

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A view from inside the bridge. The door is open now. **Camillo Skragg** and **Penny Skragg** lean over to look through the doorway. On the other side, **Peter Cat** and **Jinx Bubastis** also lean the other direction to look through the doorway on the other side. No one speaks.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis breaks the silence and points the stations out on the bridge. One station has some equipment – the Reyll navigation computer – held in place with duct tape.

Jinx Bubastis

Well. The helm's in front, and the side panels can be configured for communications, gunnery, admin, or analysis.

Penny Skragg

Neat! Hey, is that *duct tape*?

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

In the hallway, **Camillo Skragg** asks **Peter Cat** a question.

Jinx Bubastis

Yeah, the navigator didn't fit in a standard rack mount.

Camillo Skragg

I was wondering something.

Back in that lab, they called the thing I was working on an *interocitor*.

Is that the real name or did they take it from an old movie called "This Island Earth"?

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat looks up and thinks for a moment.

Peter Cat

Yeah, we call them that.

Panel 5 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*): **Peter Cat** and **Camillo Skragg** walk together down the hallway, following **Jinx Bubastis** and **Penny Skragg**.

Peter Cat

But it wouldn't surprise me if it's because of that movie.

Page 21

Panel 1 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

The **Bastard Sun** hangs in deep space. The dome on the end of the crew hull has been set to transparent. Small, ghostly lights are visible beneath the geodesic structure.

Box (narration, top left)

Not long enough ago, not far enough away.

Demonlayer (from inside dome)

Enter!

Box (narration, lower right)

The *Bastard Sun*, headquarters of the “*Reyll terrorist cell*” M-Seven.

Panel 2 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

In the foreground, **Demonlayer** seems to levitate above the floor, in a posture similar to but slightly different from the lotus position, called “hunters’ repose”. She is actually sitting on an invisible *soft chair* created by the gravity simulators in the dome. The landscape of the dome is a kind of terrarium, planted with strange luminous plants. A plethora of extremely kitschy replicas of Fe Arran tallow lamps with simulated flames like candles surround her. Behind her, in a dramatically lit circle of light, stands **Champion**, who points at her and tries to get her to acknowledge him. Her eyes are closed, she resents the interruption.

Champion

Listen up, *Demonlayer*!

The Freeze and *Vandal* have bailed.

I let them go.

If you pull any psycho shit, you’ll answer to *me*.

Panel 3 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

A close-up of **Demonlayer**’s face. She looks terribly tired, and her eyes are barely open. Her words hang in the dark background.

Demonlayer

Did you *really* think I’d be angry?

You don’t matter, *Number Six*.

Champion (off-panel)

The name’s *Champion*, asshole.

Demonlayer

You are *Number Six*

and *I* have been planning for the *future*.

Come here and observe.

Page 22

Panel 1 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Demonlayer makes a theatrical gesture. A somewhat familiar image hovers above **Demonlayer** and **Champion**, an image of the *Source*. In the center, a bright white dot blinks.

Champion

Is this about our *next booking*?

Demonlayer

Very perceptive!

Before you, there was *another Number Six*.

One who wasn't as smart or powerful as she thought.

Now she and her *meat robot* are in the *sky tumor* whence *the Corporation metastasized*.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A close-up of **Demonlayer** as she continues speaking.

Demonlayer

To do this, they required a *navigation computer*.

One that I am capable of *tracking*.

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Champion side-eyes **Demonlayer** with obvious contempt and skepticism.

Champion

See, that's what I was talking about with "psycho shit"...

...you're *stalking* the old *Number Six*?

Panel 4 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*): **Demonlayer** and **Champion** look at the blinking white dot in the holographic display.

Champion

Why? What could you *possibly* gain from this?

Demonlayer

Leverage, *Champion*.

Control over the story.

Make it happen on *OUR* terms. Do you see?

Page 23

Panel 1 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

Inside the open-ended cage-like structure of a deep space depot, which vaguely resembles an open claw clip, the **Nightstalker** unloads crew and takes on stores. A voice comes from one side of the dome on top of the main hull – **Jolt's** voice.

Box (narration, upper left)

Meanwhile, “space cops” *Honor Guard* get ready for a fresh support crew, and refill the *Nightstalker's* stores...

Jolt

Thanks for making time for me, Angela.
Pardon my temper, dear but...

Panel 2 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

A darkened conference room inside the **Nightstalker**. **Jolt** holds up two pages of hard copy, letting them dangle from her pinched thumb and index finger. She points at them for emphasis. She is not a happy person.

Jolt

...what the *fuck* is this?
This isn't a *booking*, this is an *artillery strike* on our set!

Panel 3 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

A glowing projection of **Angela**, a well-composed female Fe Arran agent working for “Fun Division”.

Angela

It's OK, *Jolt*. I know Peter and Jinx haven't had much media presence—

Jolt (off-panel, interrupting)

NO heat, Angela. *None*. You didn't even use their *codenames*!

Angela

—but the *writers* say they've got a surprise in store.

Panel 4 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jolt has dropped the hard copy on the table of the conference and looks at Angela with exasperation. She is mad, but she's also making a visible effort not to start yelling at **Angela**.

Jolt

Darling, when those two go *off-script*, it's not a *surprise*, it's an *atrocity*.
I've seen *footage* of *Magrige*!

Panel 5 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Angela tries to reassure **Jolt**.

Angela

They say Peter's *mellowed out*—

Jolt (off-panel, interrupting)

—he was supposed to be *drooling* into a *pillow*.
What happened?

Angela

It was unscripted.
The writers had to *improvise*.

Panel 6 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jolt has fully banished her anger. Her expression shifts to concern.

Jolt

I'm sorry, Angela, I'm just upset.
What happened to *Victor*?

Panel 7 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Angela is visibly uncomfortable.

Angela

Victor Bravo was performing an *extrajudicial*—

Jolt (off-panel, interrupting)

—was out with his *death squad*, Angela, we can talk like grown women.

Angela

Target was a *Reyll* engineer.
Jinx intercepted the op.

Page 24

Panel 1 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jolt looks down and is quiet as **Angela** continues speaking. She seems sad at what she is hearing.

Angela (off-panel)

There was *permanent damage*. His *neurosurgeon* and his *OptCond® LifeCoach™* did their best.

Panel 2 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Angela seems to be relieved as the conversation comes to an end.

Jolt (off-panel)

Tell the *writers* he's stumbling over his lines.

Any *words* over two syllables.

That's not *funny*, it's *cruel*.

I *care* about *Honor Guard*, and I *care* about him!

Angela

I will.

Jolt (off-panel)

Thanks, darling. That'll do for now.

Panel 3 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jolt sits for a moment in the dark conference room as **Angela's** projection fizzles out. She looks sad and thoughtful.

Panel 4 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jolt walks out through a sliding door into a wide, well-lit corridor on the **Nightstalker**. She is slightly startled by a voice coming from **X.O. Persh** from behind, off-panel.

X.O. Persh

Hey! Jolt!

Panel 5 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jolt gamely tries to smile as **X.O. Persh** walks up to her and offers her a cartridge, which she accepts.

X.O. Persh

Don't worry about the crew rotation, it's just taking longer than usual.

I want you to have this.

If something goes wrong, you'll be able to take command.

Jolt

Thank you, sir. Enjoy your leave!

Panel 6 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

A close-up on **Jolt** as she leans with her back to the wall, clutching the cartridge to her bosom. She looks like she is going to burst into tears. In the background, **X.O. Persh** briskly walks down the hall.

Box (unobtrusive, lower right)

"Honesty's an actor's worst mistake" – Mission of Burma